I'll Take You Back (No Matter Your Scars)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55740754.

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Suicide, Suicide Attempt, Chipped Catra (She-Ra), dislocated shoulder, That's the "graphic depiction of violence", And a few broken bones

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by GrahminRadarin

Summary

Adora arrives on Prime's ship to save Catra, and she still will. Just not from Prime. This time, she's saving Catra from herself. Prime and most of the clones died when he chipped Catra because he wasn't prepared to deal with a mind that already had someone in it, and Catra's been stuck on the ship alone ever since. She's not taking it well.

Notes

This has been finished and sitting on my hard drive for at least a year at this point, probably longer. I just kept forgetting to upload it. I am. Way too obsessed with how perfect of a metaphor the chips are for how cults and fascism force people to believe who they are is wrong. SO I wrote a fic subverting that entire premise. Obviously. Hope you enjoy it! There might be a NSFW sequel, might not be. We'll find out.

Adora didn't know what to expect from Prime besides utter cruelty and ruthlessness, but complete and utter silence seemed out of character. Somehow, it scared her more than any of the countless scenarios she had imagined in the weeks spent getting here.

The empty hangar yawned open in front of Darla like a deep abyss, with a single bright sickly green light set in a door at the far end being the only thing not lost to the void. Adora narrowed her vision to that door and tamped down her fear, summoning the anger that had fueled her for these past weeks. *I'm here for Catra. I'm going to rescue her. I'm going to take her home.*

She stepped forward and shouted, "PRIME!" The challenge echoed through the darkness.
"I'm here to talk! Where are you?"

Nothing responded.

In her ear, she heard Glimmer whisper, "Adora? What's happening?"
"There's no one here," Adora said. "I don't know what's happening; just stick to the plan exactly, okay? Don't change *anything.*" She squared her shoulders, drew herself up straight. The door light blinked in invitation. Adora stepped forward into the darkness.

* * *

Adora was hopelessly lost. Every corridor was identical, and none of them had distinct rooms to use as waypoints. Even Entrapta wouldn't be able to navigate this place. Not unless there were vents she wasn't seeing. Assuming Horde Prime had a control room of some kind, she was never going to find it. She was beginning to doubt her ability to remember the path back to the hangar and Darla, much less find her way in new places.

Adora abruptly stopped. She couldn't get lost in a panic now. She started counting her breaths, timing them to slow down her mind before it could start racing. She opened her eyes again and made to keep walking forward.

There was the faintest noise, like something hard and organic scraping softly over metal. Adora's head snapped around. Then it snapped the other way. The sound had come from… at least one of four directions in the intersection. Everything echoed, almost like the acoustics were designed to be confusing. For all she knew, they were. Adora made a guess and turned right.

Everything on the ship had been starkly lit in off white or disturbingly organic green. This corridor was dark. One side had oddly patterned metal triangles at regular intervals along the wall. Adora walked with a purpose, faster than she had before. The triangles slowly irised open as she went, revealing windows. Windows out into space. The sight of the stars, glimmering out there, beyond everything any Etherian had known for thousands of years, still amazed her. If only Catra could see them.

There was another noise, down the corridor. Someone was breathing, gasping for air in a panic. Their breath hitched, and Adora knew that sound.

Catra.

Her steps quickened, the world around her fell away and her vision narrowed to the corridor's end. It lay around a bend, hidden by shadows. Adora broke into a dead sprint, flinging herself headlong into those shadows. Nothing would ever matter to her as much as this one moment.

"Catra!", she called, not wanting to wait for her legs to bring them together. There was a soft *whoosh* further forward in the dark.

"CATRA!"

* * *

When Adora reached the end of the corridor, there was a door. She didn't care.

THUNK

She cried out as she hit it. Something in her shoulder snapped and the bones *slipped* and it felt wrong, it was so wrong- Her head hit next, and she lost her train of thought.

She bounced off the door and staggered back a step. Her arm hung uselessly at her side. She glared at it and went to pry open the door, but her arm wouldn't move. No time to think about that, Catra was here, she was on the other side of this door, Adora was going to save her. A growl rose in her throat and her vision went red around the edges. A simple metal door wouldn't stop her now. She raised her good arm, slowly made a fist and pulled back to her shoulder. Her fist shot forward like a ballista, right into the door.

Bones snapped. The pain went unfelt.

Adora punched it again. And again. It might have dented. She slumped against the door, holding herself up with the outstretched fist. *No. I'm not leaving her again. I'M* NEVER *LEAVING HER AGAIN.* She pulled back her fist once more. She breathed in and huffed out anger. She breathed again. She screamed, primal and furious. The walls and floors began to reflect a faint blue and purple glow, and the lights seemed to dim around her. The glow brightened, becoming an aura. Adora's eyes flashed white, and she let her fist fly.
The walls shook and the door crumpled inward around her fist, then gave like soft cheese. It broke away from its frame and silently tumbled into the void on the other side. The room revealed beyond was massive. It extended infinitely up and down, each level and open ring around a central column of nothing. Four bridges led to a central platform on this level, suspended in the center. A massive screen framed an empty throne facing Adora.

"Catra! Where are you?" Adora cried out. "Catra? CATRA?"

Someone whimpered behind the throne. Adora ran across the bridge. The pain from her shoulders and hands hit her halfway across, and she stumbled, almost falling to her knees. She hissed and continued to limp forward. Her steps echoed in the darkness. When she came to the throne, she slowly moved to look behind it.

Catra was there. But it wasn't her. Her mask that she had treasured for so many years was gone, her hair was expertly cut to only the neck, and her suit was white. There was a black Horde symbol on her back and she wore a small cloak. Her arms were bare. She was lying on her side, curled in on herself, facing away from Adora. Hiding. Adora reached out to her. Catra flinched away.

"Catra?", she whispered. Catra uncurled and turned to look at her. She stared in disbelief.

"…Adora?", Catra croaked. Her voice sounded like it hadn't been used in days. "Are you… real?"

Adora laughed and said "I'm here, Catra. I'm really here." She reached out, slowly, to touch Catra again. Catra let her.

Catra's whole body relaxed at her touch, like she had been tensing everything for weeks and forgotten to let go. Her heart began to slow, and the endless assault on her senses finally abated. It was almost too perfect to be real. She closed her eyes and tried to push into the hand. She wanted to stay forever. It was almost too perfect to be real.
Adora withdrew her hand, and Catra reached for her. Adora grunted, and the was an audible grinding followed by a sharp *pop!* before she sighed in relief. Catra began to ask what she had done, when Adora wrapped her in her arms and pulled her closer. Her hands might have been made of silk, for how soft their touch was. Catra froze in confusion. Adora's touch slid up and down, gliding all over her back, feeling every inch of her fur and skin. Catra's eyes began to water. She nuzzled Adora's chest, listening to her heartbeat and closing her eyes to everything around her. Her world shrank to Adora's hands and heart. Adora slowly felt

over Catra's back, pulling the knots from her unwashed fur. They hadn't been this close in 2 years.

Finally, Adora couldn't move any slower, and her hands worked their way up to Catra's neck. Tenderly sliding up, something felt wrong. The skin was tight, like it was being pulled- Something cold touched her hand. Catra heard Adora's heart skip, literally *skip* a beat, and they both froze. One in horror, the other in fear.

"Adora, I- I- It's not…", she slowly stuttered, watching Adora's face work from confused to horrified. "Adora, I'm- I'm okay, I'm fine-" Adora wordlessly pushed Catra out to arm's length and flipped her onto her chest. Catra begged, "Adora please, no, don't, just… please." She didn't listen and brushed aside the fur on her neck. The sound she made was much the same as if Catra had died. Her voice trembled in despair.
"Catra.. wh-what did he do…?"

Catra's voice mirrored the trembling in hers, and rasped "Why did you come back? You never came back when I asked. I've never mattered before, why now?" Her voice began to grow. "Is it because I'm broken now? You only ever care when I'm hurt, when I fail, because then you get to help! It's always about you being the good one, being the hero!" She had thrown Adora off and was up on her elbows. She was shouting now. "It's always about you! I do one good thing and suddenly you can't leave me alone because you need to be better than me!" Her voice broke. She looked down and carried on in a whisper, "You never cared about me, did you?" She flopped down on her chest lay there, silent.

Barely louder than the ambient wind of the room, "Why do you always have to save me? Just leave me here. You can't help anymore."

Catra's tail twitched, and she pulled her arms under her. Slowly, she rose, and Adora kept waiting for Catra to turn and face her. She didn't. She took one halting, unsure step away, towards the edge, and another. Catra stumbled to the precipice and looked

down. Her arms were wrapped around her torso in a hug that did nothing to shield her from her thoughts. The darkness below looked inviting.

Adora had stayed frozen, staring. Now she finally found the courage to speak. “Catra, I–that’s–I came back because-because I want you”, she said. The words stumbled out of her mouth like they could barely walk. “I… I didn’t know before, but I do now. I want you, not because I can save you. You’re my best friend, and– and you’re not broken. Whatever happened to you, we can fix it. But I still want you, even if we can’t. I promise, I’m not leaving you, ever again.”

Catra stared into the abyss. It didn’t return the favor.

“Please…come back to me.” Adora stood where she was, waiting. Her voice softened. "Please don't go."

Catra’s life had already been ripped away once. She would not give it up again. Not now. Not when she could have it all to herself. Not when she could have Adora again.

She stepped back from the edge.

Turning to Adora, her mask fell away. She sniffed, and Adora cautiously went to her, stopping just before they touched. Adora held out a hand, tentative, delicate, and full of hopeful promise for them both, the other over her heart. They looked each other deep in the eye. For the first time Adora noticed Catra had no pupils or sclera– only a solid pale blue and a solid deep yellow iris. Catra, for her part, saw the longing in Adora’s eyes. Longing for her.

They rushed into each other’s arms and held tightly as if they could never leave. Tears flowed down Adora’s back. Droplets began to fall on Catra’s fur. Together, they fell to their knees and wept.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!